

Chapter 5

Echoes in the Dark

The office had finally fallen silent.

One by one, the lights across Northbridge Group disappeared until only a few floors remained illuminated.

Elara closed the last file on her desk and leaned back in her chair.

It had been another long day.

Meetings.

Reports.

Decisions.

Yet none of them had managed to distract her.

Because somewhere, hidden beneath every thought...

Was that folded note.

"The truth is never buried... it only waits."

She slowly picked up her bag and left the office.

By the time she reached home, the mansion was unusually quiet.

Dinner had already ended.

After exchanging a few words with her mother, Elara quietly walked upstairs to her room.

She closed the door behind her.

The room was dark except for the faint glow of the city lights outside her window.

She placed her phone on the bedside table.

Changed into something comfortable.

Then, almost without thinking...

She walked toward the drawer beside her bed.

For a few seconds...

She simply stared at it.

Her hand hesitated.

Slowly...

She pulled the drawer open.

There it was.

Roman's bracelet.

Exactly where she had left it.
She picked it up carefully.
Her thumb brushed across the worn leather.
A faint smile appeared...
Only to disappear a second later.
Three years.
And somehow...
She still couldn't bring herself to throw it away.
She sat on the edge of the bed.
The room was silent.
But her mind wasn't.
Questions she had buried years ago began returning one after another.
Why did Roman disappear?
Was he really guilty?
Or had everyone believed the wrong story?
She looked down at the bracelet once more.
Then suddenly...
She stood up.
Almost as if her heart had already made the decision before her mind could stop it.

An hour later...
Frankfurt slept beneath a cold midnight sky.
The streets were nearly empty.
Streetlights stretched long shadows across the pavement.
Elara parked her car a short distance away.
In front of her...
Stood the abandoned library.
The building looked nothing like she remembered.
Cracked windows.
Peeling walls.
Rust covering the old entrance sign.
Nature had begun reclaiming what people had forgotten.
For a long moment...
She simply stood there.

Then she pushed the old wooden door.

Creeeeak...

The sound echoed through the empty building.

She switched on her phone's flashlight.

A narrow beam of light cut through the darkness.

Dust floated lazily in the air.

Broken shelves leaned against the walls.

Books lay scattered across the floor, their pages yellow with age.

Every step she took echoed back at her.

She tightened her grip on the bracelet.

Her heartbeat grew louder.

She slowly walked toward the room...

The room she had spent three years trying to forget.

The room where Noah had taken her last breath.

Elara stopped at the doorway.

The silence felt heavier than the darkness itself.

Then...

Tak...

A footstep.

She froze.

The sound hadn't come from behind her.

It came from somewhere upstairs.

Her breathing became shallow.

She lifted the flashlight toward the staircase.

Nothing.

Only darkness.

A few seconds passed.

Then again...

Tak...

This time...

Closer.

A cold chill ran through her body.

A thought flashed across her mind.

Roman...?

Another thought followed almost immediately.

...or the third person who was here that night?

Without realizing it...

She took another cautious step forward.

Suddenly—

A strong hand grabbed her from behind.

Before she could scream...

A hand covered her mouth and pulled her into a dark room beside the hallway.

Her heart nearly stopped.

She struggled instinctively.

Then...

A low voice whispered beside her ear.

"Don't make a sound."

Both of them remained completely still.

Outside...

Slow footsteps echoed through the hallway.

Someone was there.

The footsteps slowed.

Stopped.

For one terrifying second...

It felt as though whoever was outside was standing just beyond the door.

Elara could hear nothing except her own heartbeat.

Then...

The footsteps moved again.

Slowly.

Until they finally disappeared into the distance.

Silence returned.

The stranger slowly removed his hand from her mouth.

Elara immediately stepped back.

She tried to see his face.

But the room was swallowed by darkness.

She couldn't make out a single feature.

Only one thing reached her.

A familiar fragrance.

Fresh.

Clean.

Unforgettable.

Her brows slowly drew together.

She had smelled it before.

Somewhere...

Long ago.

She looked toward the shadow standing in front of her.

Her voice trembled.

"Who are you?"

The stranger remained silent.

Then, after a long pause...

He spoke.

"You shouldn't have come here."

He turned and began walking toward the broken doorway.

"Wait!"

Elara's voice echoed through the empty room.

"What happened here?"

"Who are you?"

He didn't stop.

Within seconds...

The darkness swallowed him completely.

He was gone.

Elara rushed outside.

The hallway was empty.

As though no one had ever been there.

Only silence remained.

When she finally returned home...

The digital clock beside her bed read **2:03 a.m.**

She quietly closed the bedroom door.

Placed her phone on the bedside table.

A cold breeze drifted through the half-open window, making the curtains sway gently.

She sat on the edge of the bed.

Sleep felt impossible.

She kept hearing the same words.

"You shouldn't have come here."

She slowly closed her eyes.

Then another thought crossed her mind.

Tonight...

Someone had returned.

She looked toward the dark window.

Her fingers slowly tightened around the bracelet.

A single question refused to leave her mind.

Who keeps coming back to that abandoned library... and why?